tary's residence in Jaipur, the previous Congress government razed the heritage Laxmi Vilas Hotel to build the Rs 80 crore Mahatma Gandhi Museum. It draws barely 140 visitors a month. Similarly, in 2021, the Rajasthan Housing Board (RHB) launched chaupati, a food court on a prime plot in Pratap Nagar at a cost of Rs 8 crore, pitched as a 'new-age urban food destination'. Three years on, 60 per cent of the stalls remained shuttered. "Plots around it were sold cheap before the project, and private players profited when the rates rose later. Now, we can neither sell nor rent the place—the clientele doesn't exist," says a senior bureaucrat.

The pattern of misplaced priorities continues across projects. "I have been shown images of *Alif Laila*–like palatial structures to be built here and there, with the budget soaring from Rs 100 crore to Rs 175 crore. You do not associate Maharana's legacy and Mewar with luxury, but with patriotism, sacrifice and struggle for the motherland and its people," Vishvaraj tells INDIA TODAY. The government spent Rs 180 crore on clubs for MLAs and officers, drawing criticism for excessive spending on luxury facilities. Similarly, the Rs 40 crore Fountain Square at Mansarovar, promoted as a tourist magnet, lies deserted. "Why would anyone drive 15 km from the heritage city of Jaipur to see a musical fountain?" asks an official.

The RHB's multi-hundred-crore 'Education Hub', envisioned as a mega complex for coaching institutes, has turned into another white elephant. "It's a haunted place now," says a senior officer. IIT Jodhpur has refused to set up its proposed extension centre there, despite desperate efforts by the state government to salvage the investment.

Nowhere is the waste clearer than the Rs 1,500 crore Chambal Riverfront project in Kota. Proposed as a "game changer", it was expected to draw hundreds of thousands visitors each month. Local environmentalist Ravindra Singh Tomar, who runs a boat service on the river, had called that delusional: "You can't make people visit a riverfront full of concrete, stone and replicas of façades of popular monuments in a polluted industrial town." Now, it barely attracts a few thousand visitors a month and runs an annual loss of around Rs 20 crore.



SHRICHAND KRIPLANI
BJP MLA; ex-minister, urban development and housing

"There should be proper audit of such vanity projects so that wrongdoers and wrongdoing are identified"



SHANTI DHARIWAL
Cong. MLA; ex-minister, urban development and housing

"These projects are unique, meant to be major attractions. But the BJP government is disinterested in running them"

QUESTIONABLE CONTRACTS

BJP MLA and former UDH minister Shrichand Kriplani had accused the earlier UDH department in the state assembly of mishandling the 'waste' projects. Congress MLA and former UDH minister Shanti Dhariwal, in turn, challenged him to have the matter investigated. "These projects are unique and meant to be major attractions. But the BJP government is disinterested in running them," says Dhariwal. "In Kota, both chaupatis are shut down and the riverfront is not drawing much crowd because the Rs 64 crore I sanctioned for its publicity has not been used. The IPD costs have overrun by a few hundred crores, and the government has failed to sell the education hub."

Following the Trauma Centre fire, JDA authorities admitted that they did not have expert electrical engineers for the IPD and Cardiology Centre projects. The JDA was allegedly given the project instead of the State Road Development Corporation, an arm of the public works department (PWD). As the blame game continues for the fire, the PWD—usually entrusted with maintenance—says the hospital did not sanction the Rs 17 lakh for fire audit. "There should be proper audit of spending and the benefits of such vanity projects," Kriplani demands. In fact, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had promised an inquiry into the alleged irregularities before the 2023 assembly election, but no probe followed after the BJP took power. The same advisors remain embedded in the system.

In September, a father and daughter died when a building collapsed in Jaipur's walled city, a Unesco World Heritage Site. Just days later, another man was killed in a similar incident. Earlier this year, government school buildings collapsed in Jhalawar and Jaisalmer, killing eight children and injuring at least 30. Thousands of schools still function in unsafe structures. Tourists complain about garbage, traffic chaos and lack of toilets in Jaipur—issues that Smart City funds were meant to fix. Officials say much of that money was diverted to 'enhance' elite projects like the IPD tower.

Chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma's government, which inherited these projects, faces a tough choice: keep funding them to save the investment already ploughed in, or cut losses and redirect money to essential services. So far, the signals are mixed. There are no cost audits even where expenses are two to three times higher than normal. A senior finance department official says most of failed projects share three traits: conceived without—or with fake—feasibility studies, sanctioned with manipulated or missing cost-benefit analyses and executed without accountability.

Taxpayers, technocrats and MLAs in the state are now united in their demand: stop spending on vanity, and start spending on value. ■